

When Windows doesn't recognize the `python` command, it will either open the Microsoft Store because it thinks Python isn't installed, or you'll get a message such as "Python was not found." If the Microsoft Store opens, close it; it's better to use the official Python installer from <https://python.org> than the one that Microsoft maintains.

The simplest solution, without making any changes to your system, is to try the `py` command. This is a Windows utility that finds the latest version of Python installed on your system and runs that interpreter. If this command works and you want to use it, simply use `py` anywhere you see the `python` or `python3` command in this book.

Rerunning the Installer

The most common reason `python` doesn't work is that people forget to select the Add Python to PATH option when running the installer; this is an easy mistake to make. The PATH variable is a system setting that tells Python where to look for commonly used programs. In this case, Windows doesn't know how to find the Python interpreter.

The simplest fix in this situation is to run the installer again. If there's a newer installer available from <https://python.org>, download the new installer and run it, making sure to check the **Add Python to PATH** box.

If you already have the latest installer, run it again and select the **Modify** option. You'll see a list of optional features; keep the default options selected on this screen. Then click **Next** and check the **Add Python to Environment Variables** box. Finally, click **Install**. The installer will recognize that Python is already installed, and it will add the location of the Python interpreter to the PATH variable. Make sure you close any open terminals, because they'll still be using the old PATH variable. Open a new terminal window and issue the command `python` again; you should see a Python prompt (`>>>`).

Python on macOS

The installation instructions in Chapter 1 use the official Python installer at <https://python.org>. The official installer has been working well for years now, but there are a few things that can get you off track. This section will help if anything isn't working in a straightforward manner.

Accidentally Installing Apple's Version of Python

If you run the `python3` command and Python is not yet installed on your system, you'll most likely see a message that the *command line developer tools* need to be installed. The best approach at this point is to close the pop-up showing this message, download the Python installer from <https://python.org>, and run the installer.

If you choose to install the command line developer tools at this point, macOS will install Apple's version of Python along with the developer tools. The only issue with this is that Apple's version of Python is usually somewhat behind the latest official version of Python. However, you can still download and run the official installer from <https://python.org>, and `python3`